Theophonic

By Dave Harrity

" ... to become as plain as a host

in the hands of everybody."

-Thomas Merton

INTRODUCTION

Theophonic – "Theo" – of or relating to god and "phonic" of or relating to speech. So Theophonic is a word that means talking about god. And that's exactly what this poem does. It talk about the relationship that we each have with god from the moment of our birth to the end of our days. Again and again the concept of fear is raised.

Psalm 56:3-4 ***says . . .*** *When I am afraid, I put my trust in you. In God, whose word I praise, in God I trust; I shall not be afraid. What can flesh do to me?*

Theophonic by Dave Harrity.

To come into the world will always mean
an imposition - you can't avoid the tangled
energy very long before you see it means you must
love your neighbor as yourself. Ropes braided

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and left on the ground,
a sacred circus, ashed
elocution of the mind: a ring
left incomplete. You won't be alive long enough
to see, but there are ways to separate
the ghost from the bone, the pain
from the nerve-
the way the soul
can be recovered from the body's iron. Like
knotted hair balled out from a brush or fingernails
clipped down to the quick:
the vanity
of caring for the shell-pumice stone, dusty filed skin.
* * *
Always in becoming flesh the process
is minute –
cairn worn and smoothed, tumbling
unnoticed.
* * *
The story just as small or simple-banner flecked
with purple stars, a desert sprawl and her

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bare shoulders, his beard's wiry denim flush
against her cheeks.

How something came from nothing isn't
quite a miracle as much as attraction itself ringing
us together. And the obligations
buried deep that makes us stay and fall
in love.

And after that it's angels singing
or the small hands in the world. It's another
messiah, peripatetic star, or magus
from another place-and she
was so afraid.

* * *

And all of this isn't so much about god as it is
about how prayer comes
out of us-
and not about the words we say but how
we breathe them out, burned into the world.

* * *

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The wheeze of amniotic mess and blood
for an entire night-exhausted, piled
with the hay and gentle. A nativity
you think you know, just more
human, less to lose in desert stars: meconium
of a resting king.
Eyelids bled to crumpled sacks of stones; body
branch-bent, frail and final, the gall
of crucifixion ragged on the lip. Again, it is
the thing you think you know: golgathan clear
and crowds lose in the hanging.

* * *

This present promise of what we will become
set back from sin-tower, triptych,
dungaree: these things we make
to ascend, exalt,
restrain. It's simple as a thorn, a skim of blood.
A man carries his cross up the hill, so slight
a miracle
compared to what they've seen,
if beating bathed the clement ground clean, then

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it's almost finished:

the bright veil

of new blood ringing in the shape of what

was once a face - cheekbones bowed to

lacerated lips,

the widened ends and holes.

Skin less

defined than realized to be there. A wilted pelt

hung up on nails versus the sculpture

and the size-tower, triptych,

dungaree: the things

we make

to render names to life; the lives we live to live

eternally. And we are so afraid ...

* * *

What bones there were were there just as our

bones

are: an absent rib, this crown of thorns. And on

before the crowd he looked the same-weathered

loincloth, punctured wrists half-wild, pangeaic

metatarsals-soft sockets hold the eyes.

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This is what makes it time to ask a question and

doubt

the answers that emerge: what sits

inside you on a throne deciding what is

and isn't god? How the body changes

as it goes - and rends the heart a useless

instrument.

* * *

The storm is calmed; the baskets filled.

A canvas glad of god and the name you've made.

To say it freely and finally allowed.

This wafer placed over the canyons of the palm,

the way we take the marrow in - the way

we then forget again. The cup enameled

to the teeth like we understand the process of the

thing-

and the careful bearer spilling less

than was ever spilt before. The rail leading back to

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knees.
There aren't colors enough to write it out in ink,
to copy and to copy and to copy and –
bread of life
cup of salvation
-copy. This rail to feed for free. Amen.
We say. Amen. And walk
down remembering,
rivers to a sea.
* * *
How belief must be an edible absolution
and the body less
and less afraid
how of how it ends. Space possessed by what
was now attentive with a fuller silence.
The lamplit grains of words we can't pronounce.
And it's true that we should all be more
afraid.
* * *
This crowing morning, this lofted bell –
seeds to fall, a cup to pass from you.

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Here's where you can put your fingers:
the absence you can enter.

Engulfing griefs that should remember
what you have become:
far away
and out, waste steaming in the grass

of how the body makes its own waste.
This is a vocabulary,

how to sketch in the outlined shadows
splintered in the light of glass

or arrayed silhouettes of saints crossing
knolls, spiraled iconography.

as the deer begin to munch again,
the cutbank feast in crosses.
* * *

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What emerges when we tell ourselves
what we aren't
going to become? Or you should know you will
become it,
what you wish you never were.
* * *
As if the clavicle's immediacy is diminished
by the skin,
instead it rises to a gentle hill to bear
as this is what we've made.

All of this indefinite precision, interstices
filled up by the rain.

Think of it like this when you think of his hanging:
what exactly can you know unless you cut it open?

Bones kissed through skin.

A moment in the desert when a brightness calls us
home,

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into a cave, into the running blankness of the sand.

What it means to animate is what it means to be
afraid.

These scapes across the small divide and leave
the sheep to follow something greater, relax the
gables
and the slings.

The walk is never close enough - the bearing left
unknown . . .
* * *
-and light will guide us home again, or to
another cave.
Upright and walking; light into the world:
so afraid that we'll be ruled by what we cannot see.

So kings send out their soldiers, and blood
comes out as water. And the faithful paint it
on their doors-

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but still a generation disappears.

* * *

Always when we know we know in flickering

frames-

dopplered movement unaccountable.

Always known by what we're not

or want by what we are or wish for what we

cannot have:

a line clipped in elision, forcing it to fit.

* * *

And it's impossible to know what you are

walking to or from: a cave or a grave.

Comforted by light for sake of shadow-flurries

edged and absent in the world,

detritus atoned, etched out between the self and

stars.

A body wrapped in bands, the crushed

scraps of swaddling clothes.

Unwrapped, lilted desert flowers, and you

never know what you're walking to or from.

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